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Beijing

Beijing (北京 *Běijīng*) is China's capital and its second-largest city after [Shanghai](#), with a population of around 22 million. With a rich history as the capital of Imperial China for much of its past, Beijing became the political and cultural heart of the People's Republic of China following the [Chinese revolutions](#).

The city is renowned for its flat terrain and orderly layout. Within the city limits, you'll find just three hills, all in Jingshan Park, north of the famous [Forbidden City](#). Beijing's urban structure is marked by its concentric "ring roads," which are actually rectangular in shape, mirroring the configuration of the Forbidden City.

Beijing is a city where the old meets the new, particularly within the 2nd and 3rd Ring Roads. Here, cutting-edge technologies and modern social innovations coexist with historical architecture and alleyways. While the people of Beijing may initially seem reserved, they are warm and engaging once you get to know them. As you explore Beijing, be mindful of customs and social norms that may differ from your own; see the [China](#) article for further insights. However, Beijing is home to sophisticated urbanites, so the cultural differences here may be less pronounced than in rural areas or other cities in China's interior.

Districts

Beijing has a total of 16 districts.

Central districts and inner suburbs

The two central districts are located within or just beyond the 2nd Ring Road. This is the location of the old walled city of Beijing and is where you will find most of the sights and also a good deal of sleeping, eating and drinking and entertainment options. The districts are:

Dongcheng District (东城区 Dōngchéngqū)

covering the eastern half of the central city area. This is the most important tourist district of Beijing. Including:

- **[Forbidden City](#)**
- **[Central Dongcheng](#)**, including Wangfujing (Walking Street) and Tian'anmen Square.
- **[Chongwen](#)**, the southern third of Dongcheng, including the Temple of Heaven.
- **[Gulou](#)**, in the north-center of Dongcheng, with the Drum Tower and Nanlougouxian

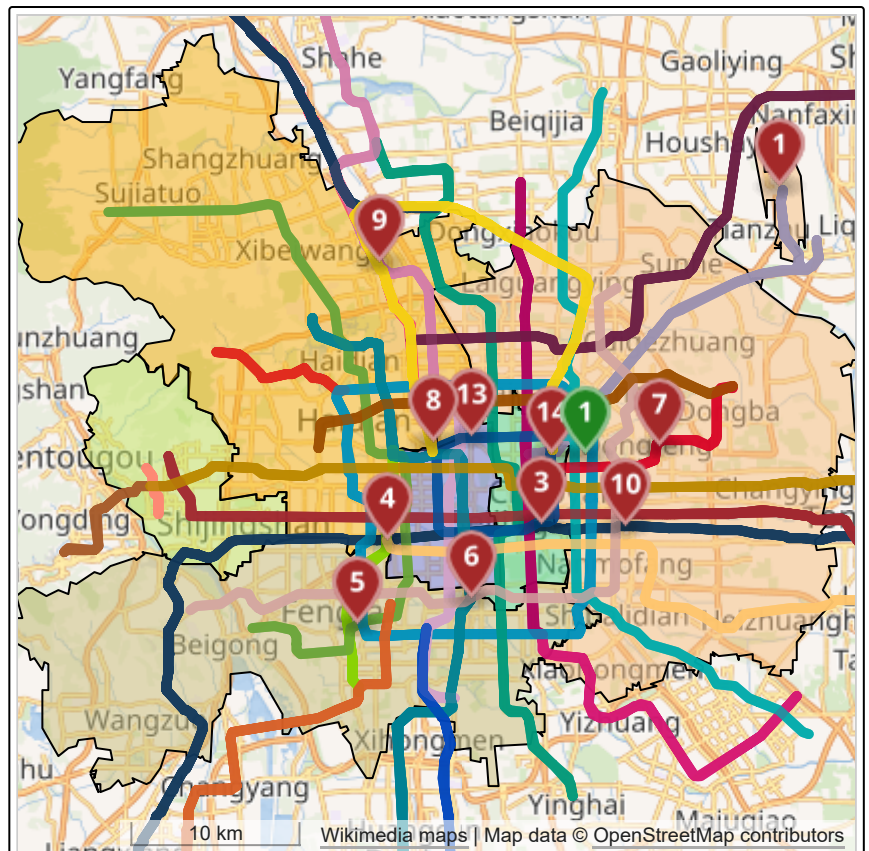
- **Dongzhimen and Ditan**, the northeast parts of Dongcheng, including Yonghegong (Yonghe Lama Temple)

Xicheng District (西城区; Xīchéngqū) covering the western half of the central city area. Includes Beihai Park, the Houhai area, Beijing Zoo and National Concert Hall.

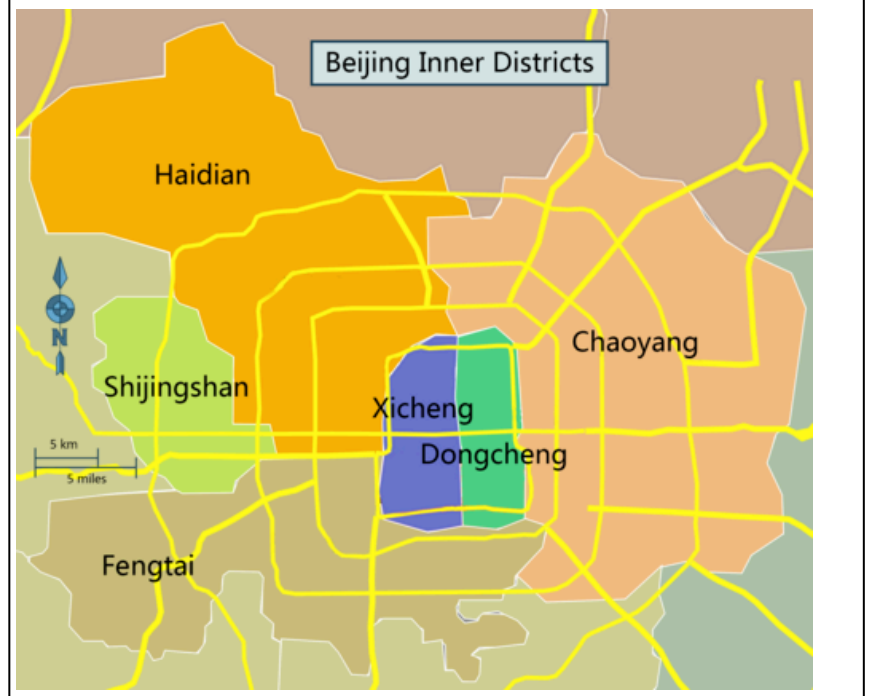
The next four districts are also fairly close to the centre, and highly urbanized. They are often referred to as the inner suburbs. Here you will find universities, Olympic venues, business and embassy areas, entertainment and bars, art districts, and parts of the Western Hills. The districts are:

Chaoyang District (朝阳区 Cháoyángqū) covers a large area east of the central city area. Includes the CBD, Olympic Green (Birds Nest, Water Cube and other 2008 Olympic venues), Sanlitun (Taikoo Li, Sanlitun Soho and Workers' Stadium), 798 Art Zone, Chaoyang Park, Ritan Park and various embassy areas

Haidian District (海淀区 Hǎidiànqū) covers the northwest of the main urban area. About half of Haidian district is made up of the Zhongguancun high technology industry and business cluster and Beijing's major concentration of



Central districts and inner suburbs



universities. Includes the Summer Palace.

Shijingshan District (石景山区 Shíjǐngshānqū)

covers some western suburbs, and parts of the Western Hills

Fengtai District (丰台区 Fēngtáiqū)

covers the southwest of Beijing. Includes Beijing West Railway Station

Rural Beijing and outer suburbs

The remaining ten districts are far from the centre.

Northern outer suburbs

Both districts are on the outer ring of suburbs but Shunyi is well integrated commuter suburb while Changping is a satellite location to the center.

- **Changping District**, home to Juyongguan, one of the most popular tourist sections of the Great Wall, and the **Thirteen Ming Tombs** (明十三陵 *Míng Shísān Lǐng*), the burial site of 13 of the 16 Ming Dynasty emperors
- **Shunyi District**, affluent suburb and a prime spot for birding

Western and southern outer suburbs

Large districts that include both extensions of the urban center and mountainous rural areas.

- **Mentougou District**, mountainous western district with many well preserved traditional villages including Cuandixia
- **Fangshan District**, caves, mountains and water sports
- **Daxing District**, a new business center and the city's second major airport

Tongzhou District (通州区 Tōngzhōuqū)

Eastern suburb, relocated administrative seat for Beijing Municipality and home to art communes.

Rural Beijing

The distant districts to the north of Beijing. The areas are a mix of satellite cities and countryside, located up to 100+ kilometers outside of the Beijing city enter.

- **Great Wall** the main line of the Ming Dynasty Great Wall passes through this northern mountainous area
- **Yanqing District**, scenic canyons and the mysterious Guyaju Caves; one of the locations of the 2022 Winter Olympics
- **Huairou District**, Mutianyu section of the Great Wall and Yanqi Lake retreat for international conferences
- **Miyun District**, Great Wall at night at the Simaitai section and adjacent Gubei Watertown
- **Pinggu District**, a UFO tower and long glass bridge over mountain scenery

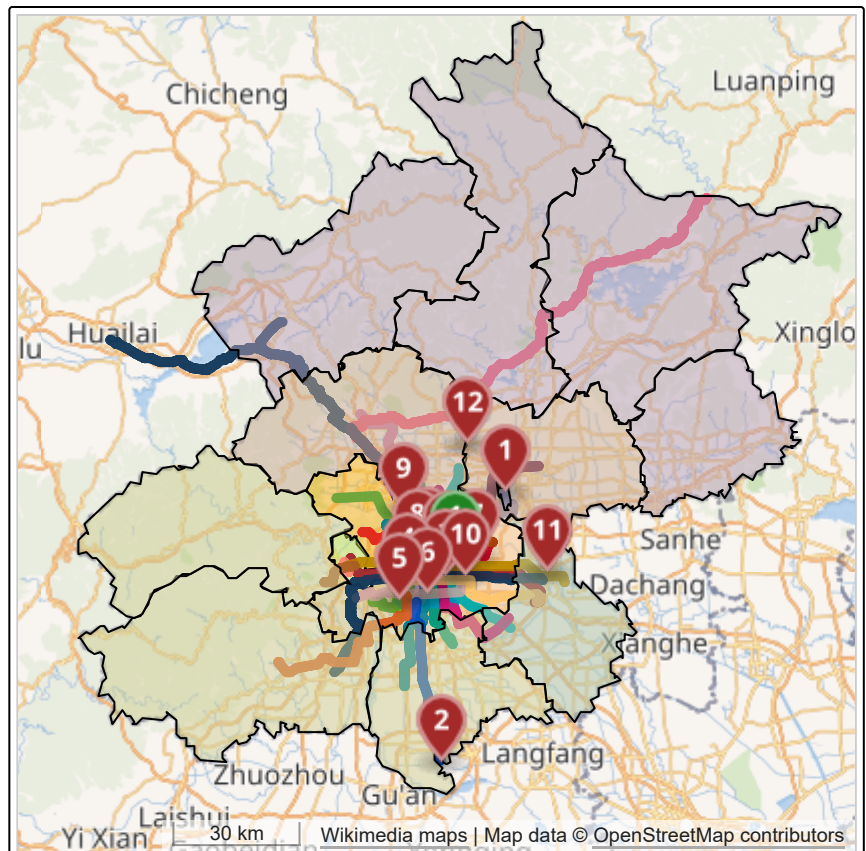
Understand

History

Beijing (formerly transliterated "Peking") literally means *Northern Capital*, a role it has played many times in China's long history. Beijing's history dates back several thousand years but it first became notable in Chinese history after it was made the capital of the State of Yan under the name *Yanjing*. Yan was one of the major kingdoms of the Warring States Period, some 2,000 years ago. After the fall of Yan, during the later Han and Tang dynasties, the Beijing-area was a major prefecture of northern China.

In 938, Beijing was conquered by the Khitans and declared the capital of the Liao Dynasty. The Mongols seized the city in 1215. From 1264 Beijing served as the capital of a united China under Kublai Khan. His victorious Mongol forces renamed the city, *Great Capital* (大都). From there, Kublai and his descendants ruled their empire from a northern location closer to the Mongol homelands. During this period, the walled city was enlarged and many palaces and temples were built.

After the fall of the Mongol-founded Yuan dynasty in 1368, the capital was initially moved to Nanjing. However, in 1403 the 3rd Ming emperor, Zhu Di, also known as Emperor Yongle, moved it back to Beijing and gave the city its present name. The Ming period was Beijing's *golden era*. The Forbidden City, the Temple of Heaven and many other Beijing landmarks were built in this period. The capital developed into a huge city becoming the religious and cultural center of Asia.



Rural Beijing and outer suburbs



In 1644, the Ming Dynasty was overthrown by the rebel leader Li Zicheng, though his rule would be short lived as he was quickly overthrown by the Manchus, who established China's last imperial line - the Qing. Despite the changing political climate, Beijing remained the capital. The Manchu imperial family moved into the Forbidden City and remained there until 1911. The Qing built both the Summer Palace and Old Summer Palace. These served as summer retreats for the emperors and their entourages. During the 19th century, Western countries established foreign legations in the Qianmen area south of the Forbidden City. These came under siege during the Boxer Rebellion in 1900.

The Qing dynasty fell in 1911 and was replaced by the Republic of China, with Sun Yat-sen as its first president. In the chaotic first years of Republican China, Beijing was beset by fighting warlords. Following the Northern Expedition, the Kuomintang moved the capital to Nanjing in 1928, and renamed Beijing as *Beiping* (北平, literally "Northern Peace") to emphasize that it was no longer the capital. Beijing remained a center for education and culture throughout the Republican Era. The Kuomintang lost the city to the Communists in January 1949. After 6 months, the new government proclaimed a People's Republic with its capital at Beijing.

After over 20 years of isolation from Western countries, the visit of US President Richard Nixon in 1972 marked a significant turning point for China. Following this visit, Beijing experienced a spurt of international visitors, leading to the addition of Block D to the historic Beijing Hotel in 1974. By the end of 1978, the era of reform and opening-up had begun, transforming the city into a thriving economic hub. In the early 1980s, Beijing welcomed hundreds of thousands of foreign tourists annually, prompting the construction of the 1,000-room luxury Great Wall Hotel, completed in 1983-84, to accommodate the growing influx.

The 1980s introduced new modes of thought and lifestyle, with the emergence of supermarkets, fast food outlets, high-rise apartments and offices, as well as numerous luxury hotels. By the 2000s, Beijing had transformed into a global city with a stunning skyline of contemporary architectural wonders, further highlighted by its hosting of the 2008 Summer Olympics. Notably, Beijing remains the only city in the world to have hosted both the Summer Olympics (in 2008) and the Winter Olympics (in 2022).

In the post-pandemic era, China has shifted its focus from Western countries to strengthening relationships with the Global South. However, effort is still made to attract European tourism, introducing short-term visa-free policies in 2024 for several European and Southeast Asian countries.

Orientation

Beijing is one of China's four municipalities (直辖市), cities that are not part of any province, and whose governments instead report directly to the central government. It is a vast city spanning 16,800 km² and divided into 16 districts, with significant distances between them. The city is bordered by Hebei province to the north, west, and south, and by Tianjin to the east. Beijing is a central part of the Beijing-Tianjin-Hebei (Jing-Jin-Ji) regional development strategy, launched in 2014, which aims to create a mega region with enhanced connectivity. High-speed rail now allows travelers to reach Tianjin from Beijing in just 30 minutes, and the newly developed Xiong'an New Area in Hebei in 20 minutes. Xiong'an is envisioned as a techno and eco-utopia, designed to relieve some of Beijing's non-capital functions, though only time will prove whether Xiong'an will prosper or not.

The city used to be almost entirely made up of hutongs with narrow lanes and single story buildings. Now, many of the hutongs have given way to broad boulevards and modern buildings, contributing to an airy, sprawling feel, in sharp contrast to cities like Hong Kong and Shanghai. Beijing is the political centre of the country, with official buildings and embassy areas dominating the city and many historical buildings and sites especially within the 2nd Ring Road.

People

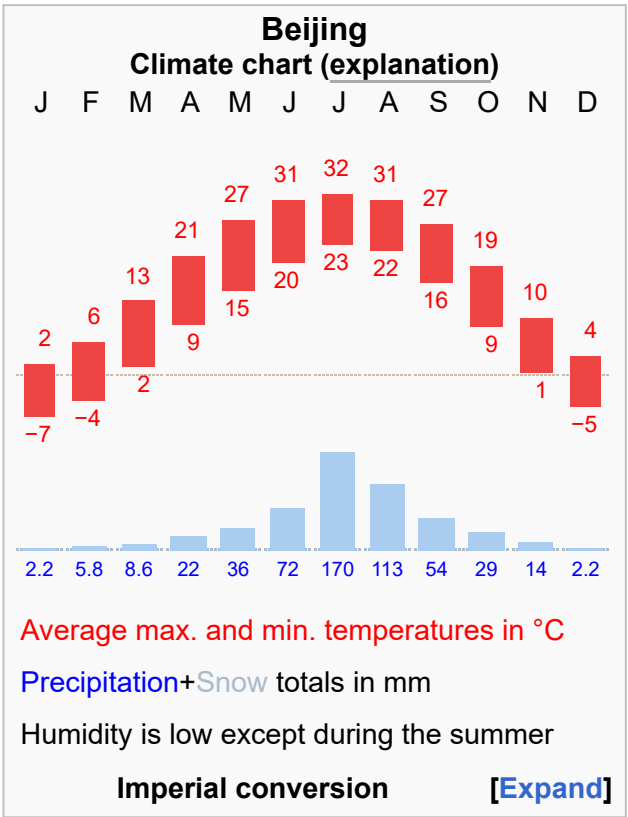
Beijingers take great pride in being citizens of the capital, given the city's historical, cultural, and political significance. This pride is sometimes described as 大北京主义 or "Great Beijing-ism," reflecting their distinct attitude toward people from other regions of China. Compared to people elsewhere in the country, Beijingers are often more interested in politics and more willing to discuss current events. They also tend to be mindful of maintaining face and frequently use humor to navigate social situations. Despite this, many Chinese from other provinces find Beijingers to be friendly and straightforward, especially when compared to people from Shanghai. The city has undergone a remarkable transformation, evolving from a fast-growing, developing metropolis with occasional horse-drawn wagons on city streets in the 2000s, into an affluent, middle-class society marked by rampant consumerism and trendy hangout spots by the 2020s.

Climate

Beijing has a monsoon-influenced continental climate with hot, humid summers and cold, dry winters. The best time to visit is in September and October, during the "Golden Autumn" (金秋). In spring, dust storms from the Gobi Desert can turn the sky yellow and significantly reduce air quality. Masks are advisable during these events. Summer can be oppressively hot and the tourist crowds tend to be the largest as well. Winter is cold and dry, with infrequent, but beautiful, snow. Temperatures can easily fall below $-10\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$ in winter and or just as readily rise above $35\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$ in summer as well.

Demographics

As of 2022, Beijing's permanent resident population stood at 21.84 million, with a registered population of 14.28 million. This difference is largely due to the difficulty many residents face in obtaining hukou, the household registration that grants access to better education and welfare services in the city. Beijing has been actively managing its population growth. The city has seen a continued decline in birth rates among its permanent residents in line with a wider national trend.



Read

Explore books by foreigners who have experienced life in Beijing. This tradition started as early as the 13th century with the Travels of Marco Polo, where he gives an account of the layout of the city and its people during the time of Kublai Khan.

In the 1990s, two Peace Corps volunteers went on to write books about Beijing. *The Last Days of Old Beijing: Life in the Vanishing Backstreets of a City Transformed* by Michael Meyer (2008) offers an account of life in one of Beijing's remaining hutong neighborhoods, blending personal experiences with the city's modern architectural history. Peter Hessler, a writer for the *New Yorker* in Beijing during the 2000s, wrote *Oracle Bones* (2006), exploring the lives of ordinary people in China while documenting the country's transformation.

For a historical perspective, *Peking Picnic* by Ann Bridge, a bestseller from the 1930s, provides a glimpse into the city and expat life through the eyes of a British diplomat's wife. Other significant works include Sir Harold Acton's *Peonies and Ponies* (1941), Sir Reginald Fleming Johnston's *Twilight in the Forbidden City* (1934), and Juliet Bredon's *Peking - A Historical and Intimate Description of Its Chief Places of Interest* (1922), written by an Englishwoman who grew up and lived in Beijing until 1924.

Talk

The language of Beijing is Mandarin Chinese. Mandarin was the imperial court language of the Ming and Qing dynasties, and Standard Mandarin is based mainly on the Beijing dialect. For language students, this makes Beijing an excellent place to practice your Mandarin. That being said, Beijing dialect has the "er" sound at the end of many words. Hence the ubiquitous lamb kabobs (羊肉串 *yáng ròu chuàn*) become "*yáng ròu chuànr*". In addition, the Beijing dialect consists of many local slang words and expressions which have not been incorporated into standard Mandarin. Beijing taxi drivers are famously chatty and will gladly engage students of the language, offering excellent chances to practice the language and get a feel for the changes in the city and country from an "Old Beijinger".

English speakers are not common in Beijing, so it's advisable to carry your hotel's business card in case you get lost. Likewise, ask the hotel staff to write down the names of any tourist attractions you plan to visit in Chinese, so locals can help direct you. The Baidu translation app has a picture translation option that can be very useful.

Other European languages are far less widespread than English.

Get in

Visas

See also: [Visa requirements for China](#)

Travelers from 54 countries can enjoy a visa-free stay of up to 240 hours (10 days) when transiting through Beijing to a third country. This policy allows visa-free movement within designated areas across 24 provinces, autonomous regions, and municipalities. For example, you

could fly from Japan to Beijing, visit Xi'an, Guilin, and Shanghai, and then continue to Hong Kong. To qualify, you must have an onward ticket to a different country from the one you arrive from and the necessary entry documents for your destination. Hong Kong, Macau and Taiwan are considered separate countries with regard to this scheme.

By plane

Beijing (**BJS** ^{IATA} for all airports) is served by two major international airports; **Beijing Capital International Airport** is older and larger of the two, while **Beijing Daxing International Airport** is a newer airport opened in September 2019. Eventually, the plan is for Star Alliance carriers to serve Capital, and for Skyteam and OneWorld carriers to serve Daxing. Nanyuan Airport, which used to serve China United Airlines, has been closed and all its flights have been transferred to Daxing.

- **1 Beijing Capital International Airport** (北京首都国际机场 *Běijīng Shǒudū Guójì Jīchǎng* **PEK** ^{IATA}), ☎ +86 010-96158. Open 24 hours all day. Beijing's main airport is located 26 km northeast of the city center. It serves numerous domestic and international destinations and is the primary hub for **Air China** (<http://www.airchina.com>). The most convenient way to reach downtown is by taking the Capital Airport Express subway line with a fare of ¥25. Trains operate every 10-15 minutes between 06:30 and 23:00, departing from Terminal 2 and stopping at Sanyuanqiao on Subway Line **10**, Dongzhimen on Line **2**, and Beixinqiao on Line **5** (the Beixinqiao section opened on 31 Dec 2021, and some maps may not yet reflect this). The journey to the city takes 25 minutes, after which you'll need to purchase a separate ticket for the Subway. Outbound trains reach Terminal 3 in 25 minutes, and Terminal 2 ten minutes after that. From Terminal 1, it's an 8-minute walk to Terminal 2. (updated Feb 2022 |)
- **2 Beijing Daxing International Airport** (北京大兴国际机场 *Běijīng Dàxīng Guójì Jīchǎng*, **PKX** ^{IATA}), ☎ +86-010-96158. Shaped like a phoenix—or perhaps a starfish—this airport aims to handle 100 million passengers annually as a major international hub. Designed for efficiency, it features automated check-in with facial recognition, and travelers can walk from security to the farthest gates within eight minutes. The airport is accessible via the Daxing Airport Express, which connects to the Beijing Subway's outer loop line **10** at Caoqiao. Tickets cost ¥35, and machines require ID (non-Chinese passports are not accepted), so purchasing a ticket from a human cashier is the easiest option for new arrivals. The Beijing–Xiong'an high-speed intercity railway links Daxing Airport to Beijing West Railway Station, which offers additional subway connections and serves as a gateway to the high-speed rail network. By the end of 2024, the Huairou–Daxing Airport intercity railway will open, providing another high-speed rail connection, eventually extending to Capital Airport. (updated Sep 2023 |)



Interior of Beijing Daxing International Airport

By train

See also: [Trans-Siberian Railway](#)

The following are the principal stations of Beijing:

- **3 Beijing Railway Station** (北京站 *Běijīng Zhàn*). In the heart of the city, served by Subway Line **2**. Destinations include [Changchun](#), [Chengde](#), [Dalian](#), [Fuzhou](#), [Guangzhou](#), [Hangzhou](#), [Harbin](#), [Hefei](#), [Jilin](#), [Nanjing](#), [Qiqihar](#), [Shanghai](#), [Shenyang](#), [Suzhou](#), [Tianjin](#), and [Yangzhou](#).

High speed trains to the Northeast leave from this station, plus conventional trains to Ulaanbaatar in Mongolia, to Russia and to North Korea.

Public transport at this station:

- **Subway line 2**. The subway entrance can be seen as soon as you get out of the mainline station.
- **Taxis** may be expensive and slow.
- **Buses**: many run to or alongside the station. The bus stops are *Beijing Railway Station East* (北京站东 *Beijingzhandong*) and *Beijing Railway Station* (北京站 *Beijingzhan*). Don't get off at Beijing Railway Station Crossing West or East (北京站口东/西), which are some distance from the station.



Beijing South Railway Station



- **4 Beijing West Railway Station** (北京西站 Běijīng Xīzhàn). This is nowadays the main station for high speed trains across China, and also has conventional trains. Destinations include Changsha, Chengdu, Chongqing, Datong, Fuzhou, Guangzhou, Guilin, Guiyang, Hefei, Hohhot, Hong Kong (West Kowloon station), Kunming, Lanzhou, Lhasa, Nanning, Ningbo, Qinhuangdao, Sanya, Shenzhen, Taiyuan, Urumqi, Wuhan, Xi'an, and Xiamen. The twice-weekly through-carriage from Hanoi in Vietnam arrives here, though it's quicker to change in Nanning; high speed trains don't yet cross any international borders. (updated Dec 2019 |)

Public transport at West station:

- **Subway lines 7 and 9**.
 - **Taxis**: there is an underground taxi rank, which usually has at least a ten minute queue. Taxis may be expensive, especially if you have that tourist stench about you. Inevitably a tout will offer to take you out of the queue for an agreed price, but this will result in a significantly higher fare.
 - **Buses**: There is an immense amount of packed public buses that reach most destinations around downtown Beijing - however this can be difficult to navigate. These leave from several locations including the south square of the train station, west of the train station (there is a largish bus station here) and north of the station on Lianhuachi E. Road. If you are desperate to get on the public bus, there is a large sign indicating the routes close to the bus stops on the south side (the side closer to the station) of Lianhuachi E. Road.
- **5 Beijing Fengtai Railway Station** (北京丰台站 Běijīng Fēngtái Zhàn). One of the new generation stations built in the 2020s, Fengtai Railway Station served by Subway Line **10** and **16**. It is constructed to redirect conventional rail traffic from Beijing and Beijing West Railway Stations, though the station also serves several high-speed services.
 - **6 Beijing South Railway Station** (北京南站 Běijīng Nánzhàn). This station is used only by high-speed trains. It offers 70 high-speed services every day to Tianjin, Tanggu, Jinan, Qingdao, Shanghai, Hangzhou and Fuzhou. There are also a few services from Beijing South to northeastern China as well as Xiamen. Served by subway Lines **4** and **14** and public buses. (updated Mar 2018 |)
 - **7 Beijing Chaoyang Railway Station** (北京朝阳站 Běijīng Cháoyáng Zhàn). One of the new generation stations built in the 2020s, Chaoyang Railway Station was built to serve high-speed railway services to Northeastern China. The station is served by neighbouring Chaoyang Subway Station of Line

- *Subway line* .
- *Buses:* Nearby bus routes include No. 413, which connects to **14** Dongfeng Beiqiao and **10** Liangma Qiao, as well as No. 911, which connects to **6** Qingnian Lu.
- **8 Beijing North Railway Station** (北京北站 Běijīng Běizhàn). Located in Haidian District, the station serves the Beijing-Zhangjiakou High-Speed Railway, with routes to Inner Mongolian and Shanxi cities like Hohhot, Baotou, and Datong. The station is also the starting point for the **BCR Huaimi** Line and is conveniently located adjacent to Xizhimen subway station.

Beijing has several lesser-known high-speed rail stations that are less crowded and are connected to limited destinations.

- North of Beijing North Railway Station, **9 Qinghe Railway Station** (清河站) handles some high-speed trains to Chongli and Hohhot. It also stops at the Badaling section of the Great Wall. The station connects to subway lines **13** and **Changping**, as well as the **BCR Huaimi** Line. The west square of the station is accessible via several bus routes, including No. 521, No. 623, and No. 专139.
- In Chaoyang District, **10 Beijing East Railway Station** (北京东站) primarily serves Chengde, Handan, and Ji County. The **BCR Sub-Central** line provides connecting services to Beijing and Beijing West Railway Station, as well as suburban areas like Tongzhou and Fangshan.
- Located within the 6th Ring Road in Tongzhou District, **11 Beijing Tongzhou Railway Station** (北京通州站) serves intercity railway services to Tangshan. Subway line **6** serves the station.
- In the northern suburb of Shunyi, **12 Shunyi West Railway Station** (顺义西站) is a small, less crowded station on the Beijing-Shenyang high-speed route, primarily accessible by taxi due to its distance from the city center.

By car

Foreigners are allowed to rent vehicles while in China, although they need a Chinese driving license.

Also, you will need special permission (进京证) for driving a non-Beijing license vehicle into Beijing (anywhere within 6th Ring Road), which is valid for at most 7 days, and can be applied for at most 12 times. You can apply for the permit electronically, or at the checkpoints. It will be checked in security checkpoints along the city border, and you should place the permit at the lower-left corner of the front windshield of your vehicle. Expect some queues and jams at these checkpoints.

Non-Beijing licensed motorcycles are forbidden from entering any roads within the 6th Ring Road.

By bus

As a tourist, you're unlikely to use inter-province buses since China's extensive and affordable high-speed rail system covers most destinations. Cost differences won't matter even to backpackers on a budget. However, there are still some places where a long-distance bus is necessary to travel between Beijing and other regions. For instance, the Eastern Qing Tombs near the small city of Zunhua lack a high-speed rail station, and the grasslands in far northern Hebei have no train stations, making buses the only option.

There are nine inter-province bus stations listed by Beijing Tourism (<https://english.visitbeijing.com.cn/article/47OOqHU4fvh>). Two of these are located at the airports. Daxing Airport Station (大兴机场长途汽车站) primarily serves routes to Tianjin, Baoding, Tangshan, and Langfang. Similarly, Capital Airport Station (首都机场长途汽车站) offers routes to Tianjin, Tanggu, Qinhuangdao, Baoding, Tangshan, Langfang, and Cangzhou.

Other bus stations are spread across different parts of the city. The Liuliqiao Passenger Transport Hub (六里桥长途客运站) is a major transportation center in Beijing, facilitating bus services to various provinces and serving as the main hub for long-distance buses, including those to the grasslands of Hebei. Bawangfen Long-distance Passenger Terminal (八王坟长途客运站) is another key hub, with buses traveling to destinations such as Tianjin, Hebei, Shandong, Liaoning, Jilin, Heilongjiang, Jiangsu, and Inner Mongolia. Lianhuachi Station (莲花池长途客运站) connects travelers to several provinces, including Shandong, Henan, Hebei, Jiangsu, Shanxi, Shaanxi, and Hubei, offering a wide range of long-distance bus services. Sihui Station (四惠长途汽车站) primarily offers bus services to Northeast China, Hebei, Tianjin, and parts of southern China, including the Eastern Qing Tombs. Xinfadi Station (新发地长途客运站) provides connections to Hebei, Henan, Shandong, Anhui, Jiangsu, Hubei, and Inner Mongolia. Yongdingmen Station (永定门长途汽车站) covers a wide range of destinations, including Inner Mongolia, Hebei, Tianjin, Shandong, Shanxi, Henan, Jiangsu, Zhejiang, Anhui, and Shaanxi. Finally, the Zhaogongkou Passenger Terminal (赵公口长途客运站) offers routes to Tianjin, Shanghai, Shandong, and Shanxi.

By bicycle

See also: [Cycling in China](#)

Long-distance cyclist-tourists will find National Road 109 is a pleasant way to enter or leave Beijing, though lots of work. It immediately enters steep hills on the edge of the city, but sees little traffic, is well maintained and passes through lovely landscape of farmland and forests. It's remarkable how close to Beijing you are, and how far it feels.

Get around

Beijing boasts a world-class public transportation network, featuring an extensive subway system that reaches most major tourist attractions. Frequent buses and dockless shared bicycles available outside stations complement the subway, providing convenient last-mile connectivity. Many locals use ride-hailing apps like DiDi for transportation. For visitors, ordering a taxi in English is possible through the Alipay app (using Amap) or WeChat (using DiDi). Alternatively, you can install the DiDi app and link it to Alipay for seamless payment.

Do not count on finding a taxi driver or passerby who knows English well. Neither should foreigners with minimal experience with the Chinese language put faith in their ability to pronounce Chinese place names correctly. Before embarking on a trip around

Note on maps

For the most up-to-date maps, use Baidu or AutoNavi Maps (Amap) on your smartphone. Baidu Maps is in Chinese, whilst AutoNavi Maps are available in foreign languages inside Apple Maps (when in China). Apple's built-in Maps app remains accessible and is a common alternative. Google Maps is blocked in China.

the city, it is best to print out the names of places you want to visit in Chinese characters or get your hotel front desk staff to write them out for you. When going to specific addresses, writing nearby intersections or basic directions can be helpful as well. Show the text to the taxi driver or just ask for help on the street. In general, you will have a better chance of getting help in English if you address younger people.

Crossing the road in Beijing may be challenging for pedestrians unused to the local driving styles. Before crossing, assume that none of the road users will yield to you, even if a policeman is present. Zebra crossings are often ignored. Chinese drivers frequently use their horns and may play games of chicken with pedestrians and other vehicles. Should you hear a loud horn when crossing the road, always look around as there is probably a car right behind you or heading straight for you. If you find several cars and bicycles veering towards you from different directions, do not try to run to safety; instead, stand still. For drivers and cyclists, a stationary obstacle is easier to avoid. Traffic light crossings have zebra stripes painted on the road, but you should only cross when the walk light is green. When a mass of people crosses together, cars are more likely to stop or slow down.

By subway

The Beijing Subway is one of the world's most extensive systems with 29 lines and over 500 stations covering an impressive 879 km. It is clean, reliable and efficient. The network's grid-like design and bilingual signage make it surprisingly easy to navigate, especially given its size. Announcements are also bilingual in Mandarin and English. Operating hours are from around 05:15 to 22:45, with specific times posted at station entrances.

Subway entrances are easy to spot, marked with a large blue "G" and smaller "B" inside it. Fares range from ¥3 to ¥10, with the Capital Airport Express costing ¥25 and the Daxing Airport Express between ¥10 and ¥35. Tickets are valid only on the day of purchase from the station where they were issued, so keep your ticket handy for both entry and exit.

Most stations have ticket machines with English instructions, though some stations, like Tian'anmen East, require a Chinese ID or a Foreigner's Permanent Resident ID Card for machine transactions. Other travelers can buy tickets at manned counters found at each station, though not every entrance/exit is staffed, and counter staff rarely speak English. Alternatively, you can purchase tickets using the smartphone app or a stored value card, called yikatong (一卡通), is available. An e-card can be bought in the Apple Wallet app, although this is only possible if you have a UnionPay card. Cards purchased in other cities in China with the "T-Union" marking can also be used for travel, but you cannot add value to such cards while in Beijing. The physical card can be refunded at major stations like Xizhimen and Haidianhuangzhuang.



Beijing subway map

As of Sep 2025, it is not possible for foreigners to activate a digital yikatong. This is as you need to login to the COVID-19 tracking portal, which has disabled new user registrations.

Due to Beijing's high population, rush hours can be crowded, especially on lines 1, 4, 10, and 13. Avoid peak times if possible, and keep an eye on personal belongings in crowded areas. Each station has X-ray security checks for bags, and passengers carrying liquids may be asked to drink a sip in front of security staff.

Central subway lines:

- **1** – The inaugural line going east-west, passing through popular sites like the Forbidden City, Tian'anmen Square, Wangfujing, and Universal Resort.
- **2** – The loop line following the walls of the Ming Dynasty Inner City with stops at Yonghegong (Lama Temple) and Beijing Railway Station.
- – An east-west line that passes through Worker's Stadium in the Sanlitun area, the commercial and entertainment hub of the city.
- **4** – A north-south route to the west of the Central Axis, linking the Old Summer Palace, Peking University, Renmin University, Beijing Zoo and Beijing South Railway Station.
- **5** – A north-south line located east of the Central Axis, with stops at Yonghegong (Lama Temple), the Temple of Heaven, and hutong areas in between.
- **6** – A west-east line through the city center, passing through the hutong pedestrian street of Nanluoguxiang and ending at the municipal administration center in Tongzhou.
- **8** – A north-south line through the city center, connecting attractions like the Olympic Stadium, Drum Tower, Nanluoguxiang, Wangfujing, Qianmen and Yongdingmen.
- **10** – A full circular line that loops around the city, providing easy access to various districts.



Subway station in Beijing

Airport and suburban lines:

- Capital Airport Express – Links the city center to Capital Airport.
- Daxing Airport Express – Links rest of subway system to Daxing Airport.
- **9** – Serves Fengtai district including Beijing West Railway Station.
- **13** – An elevated line serving the northern suburbs, popular with students and tech professionals in Wudaokou.

Transfers are mostly seamless, except for airport express lines, which require separate tickets.

By bicycle

See also: [Cycling in China](#)

Once known as a nation of bicycles, China saw private cars dominate the roads from the 1990s until the 2010s. However, the arrival of several dockless ridesharing bike companies, each with a distinctive color, has transformed Beijing back into a city of bikes. These bikes are now crowded everywhere and waiting at every subway station exit. The infrastructure from Beijing's days as the capital of the "Bicycle Kingdom" makes exploring the city by bike excellent. The city is flat, and all major streets have bike lanes. Bicycling is often faster than traveling by car, taxi, or bus due to traffic congestion in the motorized lanes.

Four-wheeled motorized traffic in Beijing usually observes traffic signals with the exception of making turns at red lights which is often done without slowing or deferring to pedestrians or bicyclists. Pedestrians, bicycles and all other vehicles (for example, motorized bicycles, mopeds and tricycles) generally do not observe traffic signals. Also, cars, trucks and buses do not defer to cyclists on the road so it is common for a vehicle to make a right turn from an inside lane across a bike lane with no concern for cyclists traveling in the bike lane. Sometimes a right-turning vehicle crossing a bike lane will sound its horn as a warning, but not always. Cyclists also need to be on the lookout for wrong-way traffic in the bike lanes, usually bicycles and tricycles but sometimes motor vehicles, too. Wrong-way traffic usually stays close to the curb so you move to the left to get by them, but not always. Bicycling Beijingers tend not to wear helmets, nor do they use lights at night. Few bikes even have rear reflectors. The moderate pace and sheer numbers of bicyclists in Beijing appear to make bike travel safer than it would be otherwise.



Dockless rideshare bicycles are common in downtown Beijing

While you will see cyclists use many creative paths across wide, busy intersections in Beijing, the safest way for cyclists is to observe the traffic signals (there are often special signals for cyclists) and to make left turns in two steps as a pedestrian would. But if you spend any significant amount of time cycling in Beijing, you will probably start adopting more creative approaches. These can be learned by finding a local cyclist going your way and following him or her across the intersection.

Several professional bike rental companies, as well as major hotels and some hostels, rent bikes on an hourly basis. For those who need the security of a guide, a bike touring company like **Baja Bikes Beijing** (<http://www.bajabikes.eu/en/bike-tour-beijing>) would be a great way to go.

By bus

Beijing's bus system is especially convenient for short trips, particularly when your starting point or destination is not within walking distance of a subway station. Subway stations can often be over 1 km away from your desired location, and navigating the subway system can be time-consuming, especially when factoring in entering and exiting stations. Riding the bus also gives you the opportunity to view the city as you travel, unlike the subway, which keeps you underground.



Regular bus line in Beijing

Buses are also an economical choice, particularly for those on a tight budget. While typical subway fares range from ¥3 to ¥7, bus fares start at ¥2, with distance-based pricing. You can receive a 50% discount on bus fares if you use the Beijing Transportation Card instead of paying with cash. Note that tour lines and direct express lines have their own fare systems. When using the card, remember to touch in and out on most bus lines to ensure the correct fare is charged.

Beijing buses are equipped with air conditioning, heating during winter, TVs, scrolling screens displaying stops in Chinese (often with English), and broadcast systems announcing stops in both Chinese and English. However, bus staff typically speak little English, and bus stop signs are usually in Chinese. If you need assistance, you can call the English-speaking operators at the Beijing Public Transport Customer Helpline (96166).

Bus Routes

Bus lines are numbered from 1–999. Buses under 300 serve the city center, while those 300 and above connect the city center with distant areas. Buses in the 800s and 900s link Beijing with its outer suburbs. Special lines, express services, and night buses have specific prefixes or numbering.

Directions can be obtained on AutoNavi Maps, Baidu Maps, or Mapbar. Most maps are in Chinese, but AutoNavi Maps are available in foreign languages in Apple Maps or Google Maps. Apple Maps users can also access the 'live bus' feature in Transit mode.

Most buses with a line number under 200 run daily from 05:00-23:00. Buses numbered 300 and above typically run from 06:00-22:00. Night buses usually operate from 23:20-04:50. Routes can be very crowded during rush hours (06:30-09:00 and 17:00-21:00). On major holidays, most city routes have more frequent service.

Two bus stations of particular interest to tourists are Deshengmen and Dongzhimen. Deshengmen provides access to the Badaling section of the Great Wall and locations in the northwest outskirts of Beijing, while Dongzhimen serves the northern and northeastern sections of the Great Wall, as well as other outlying destinations in the northeast.

- **13 Deshengmen Bus Station** (德胜门外长途汽车站 Dēshèngménwài Chángtú Qìchēzhàn).
- **14 Dongzhimen Bus Station** (东直门长途汽车站 Dōngzhímén Chángtú Qìchēzhàn).

By minibus

Minibuses are very common in the countryside outside the urban areas. Privately operated, most trips cost less than ¥10 per short journey and only a little more for longer journeys.

By taxi

Official taxis in Beijing are reliable and relatively inexpensive. If you don't speak Mandarin, it's advisable to have the Chinese characters for your destination ready in advance. Most people use ride-hailing apps like DiDi, accessible through the DiDi miniapp within Alipay, the preferred payment app for visitors, to call both official taxis and ridesharing services. You will likely only need to get into an official taxi directly from the airport or railway station taxi lines. While ridesharing taxis are available at these busy locations, it is often easier to wait in line for an official taxi due to the hectic nature of finding a ridesharing vehicle.



An electric taxi in Beijing



Fares and meters

If the taxi driver "forgets" to switch the taxi meter on, remind him by politely asking them to run the meter and gesturing at the meter box (请打表 *qǐng dǎ biǎo*), though most can understand "meter please", and all can understand a simple point at the meter. At the end, it is a good idea to ask for a receipt (发票 *fā piào*) also while gesturing to the meter and making a writing motion. Having a receipt is handy in case you want to make a complaint later or for business reimbursement purposes, and since the receipt has the cab number, you stand a greater chance of getting your possessions back if you forget anything in the taxi.

If you want a tour around Beijing and its vicinities, you can ask your hotel to hire a cab for one day or several days. It usually costs ¥400-600 per day, depending on where you go. You can also ask just about any driver to perform this service as most are more than willing to do so. If you have Chinese-speaking assistance, then bargain down the cost. No matter the cost, the taxi is yours for the day and will wait for you at various destinations.

Communicating with the drivers can be a problem, as most do not speak English. Many will not even pick up foreign passengers on the street due to the perceived language barrier. The solution should that happen is to go into a nearby hotel and ask the desk staff to call a cab, use a ride-hailing app, or to use a translator app.

You can ask that your hotel write your destination on a card to give to the driver. Make sure to take the hotel's card (and a map) that lists the hotel's address in Chinese. This can be a 'get out of jail free' card if you get lost and need to get back via taxi. A regular city map with streets and sights in Chinese will also help.

Avoiding scams and fakes

To avoid being taken advantage of, it is a good idea to know the rough direction, cost, and distance of your destination. If the cab goes in the wrong direction for a long distance, verify the location with the taxi driver. For scamming drivers, that is usually enough for them to go back on the right track (without ever acknowledging that they were trying to cheat you). Honest drivers will explain why they are going that way. In addition, sometimes a cab driver might tell you an extravagant price to get somewhere and tell you the meter is broken.

Dishonest drivers may attempt to hand back counterfeit bills as change. When receiving large bills like ¥50 or ¥100, check the paper quality, watermark, and the imprint's clarity to ensure they're genuine. If a bill seems suspect, it's acceptable to refuse it and ask for another. Sometimes, taxi drivers may claim that your genuine bill is fake and discreetly swap it with a counterfeit one. Always keep an eye on your money, especially when handling larger denominations. To minimize your chances of being scammed, use a ride hailing app like DiDi to call a taxi.



These drivers can scam tourists big time if a fare hasn't been negotiated beforehand

There are several "makeshift taxis" running around Beijing including a seat fixed up to the back of an electric scooter. These guys will scam you big time if you don't negotiate a clear fare beforehand. Upon arriving your destination, for a 2-minute ride, the driver will demand ¥300 and will be very belligerent if you don't pay it.

Unofficial cabs hang out around tourist sights like the Great Wall and the Summer Palace. Pirate cabs will charge you a higher fee for the journey, unless you are a good bargainer, know where you are going, and know what the right fare should be.

By car

See also: [Driving in China](#)

Driving in Beijing can be quite complicated with seemingly perpetual traffic jams. Many hotels rent cars that come with drivers for up to ¥1,000 per day. Public transport or taxis will get you to most of the main tourist sites and therefore renting a car is not often required at all.

Short visa holders (less than 3 months) can get a provisional driver's license at Beijing Capital International Airport or the transportation police stations in the city within minutes. You need to provide your passport as well as your foreign driver's license and do a small examination to confirm you don't have a physical or visual disability that affects driving. With a provisional license you can legally drive cars in China. Ask any information desk at the airport for directions.

You can find the counters of many car rental companies in the arrival hall of Terminal 2 in Beijing Capital Airport, although English is not usually spoken.

Car rental companies serving the Beijing Capital Airport include:

- **China Auto Rental (<http://en.zuche.com/>)**, Tel: +86 400 616 6666
- **Avis** also operates a car-rental service in Beijing

The daily rate of smaller, economical cars is about ¥200-300. You need to deposit around ¥3000 (possible by using CUP/VISA/MasterCard credit card).

20% of cars have to be off city centre roads on weekdays — you are affected on different days depending on the last digit of your number plate. These alternate every 13 weeks. The police have a right to fine you repeatedly if you are caught on the road when you should have left your car at home. If travelling to Tianjin by car, remember they operate the same system in tandem with Beijing's road rationing schedules. On weekends no such limits apply in either cities, which may give rise to worse jams during peak travel hours.

Vehicles without a licence registered in Beijing are subject to severe restrictions in the capital — most need a special permit to enter the part of town inside the 6th Ring Road, and for those which are granted this licence, it must be renewed nearly every week. You must have your passport / Chinese ID, driving licence and vehicle licence ("blue book", not larger registration certificate) with you at all times, especially when leaving or entering Beijing, as you will be checked by the police.

By suburban railway

The Beijing City Rail is a suburban railway system for commuters and not the typical way by tourists to get around except for the S2 in spring. The gate closes 5 minutes before departure, so be prompt. You can't book tickets in advance for the S2, so purchase them at the station. Use the Beijing Transportation Card mobile app for other lines.

The lines are as follows:

BCR S2: The S2 line runs from Huangtudian station (near Huoying subway station on lines 8 and 13) to Yanqing. This line is an excellent option for reaching the northern suburbs, particularly during the morning and evening rush hours when the freeways are highly congested. All trains stop at Badaling, a 10 minute walk from the Great Wall. Some trains also stop at Nankou station, located between Badaling and Huangtudian. This line is especially scenic during spring, making it a worthwhile choice for visiting the Great Wall. On Mondays, Fridays, Saturdays, and Sundays, service extends to Kangzhuang or Shacheng. Fares range from ¥5 for one station to ¥6 for more than one on the main line, and ¥16 from Huangtudian to Kangzhuang or Shacheng. The S2 line is the only suburban railway where you can use a standard Beijing Transportation Card, which should have a minimum balance of ¥16. It is advisable to arrive early to avoid crowds and secure a good seat. Trains can be crowded during the evening rush from the city or the morning rush into the city. First class has been abolished on Line S2 so feel free to sit anywhere you please.

BCR Sub-Central: This line runs from Liangxiang railway station (in Fangshan) to Qiaozhuang East railway station (in Tongzhou). All trains stop at Beijing West Railway Station, Beijing Railway Station, and Beijing East Station. While the line has fewer trains, it can be a smart way to travel through the city center, especially during peak hours when roads are busy, and buses and the metro are crowded. The trains are generally less crowded except for the section from Liangxiang to Beijing West.

BCR Huaimi: The line runs from Beijing North station to Gubeikou in the northeastern suburbs, passing through Huairou town and Changping North station. All trains stop at Changping North Railway Station. However, only two pairs of trains operate to/from Gubeikou per day, one in the morning and one in the afternoon. An additional four pairs of trains are available between Beijing North and Huairou North. Fares are ¥9 to Huairou North and ¥12 to Gubeikou.

BCR Tongmi: The Tongmi line starts at Tongzhou West railway station and has two branches. One branch goes to Miyun North railway station, with just one pair of trains: inbound (from Miyun) in the morning and outbound (to Miyun) in the evening. The other branch goes to Huairou North railway station, with one outbound train in the morning and one inbound in the afternoon. Maximum fares for either branch are ¥8.



BCR Huaimi train leaving Yanqihu railway station in Huairou



Beijing Transportation Card

The Beijing Transportation Card, commonly known as the Yikatong card, is a convenient way to pay for public transport in Beijing. The card can be obtained at subway stations in physical form or mobile version. When acquiring a physical card, a deposit of ¥20 is required. You can charge the card at subway stations, transit hubs, or service centers. It is worth noting that visitors with non-Chinese phone numbers have reported difficulties in getting the mini-app for the card to work within the Alipay payment app.

The card can be used mainly for:

- All buses operated by Beijing Public Transport, Bafangda buses, and Yvntong bus lines, with a 50% discount on fares.
- All subway lines, including the Xijiao tram line.
- Suburban railway line S2.

See

Individual listings can be found in Beijing's district articles

Great Wall

The Great Wall of China (长城 Chángchéng) is the must-see on any trip to Beijing and a destination worth visiting multiple times due to its vastness and the variety of views, landscapes, and hikes it offers. The Wall is located about an hour by train or 1½ hours by bus from the city (be aware of bus scams, as mentioned in the "Stay Safe" section below). For general information on the Great Wall, see **Great Wall**, and for details on specific sections, refer to **Northeastern Beijing**, **Yanqing District**, **Huairou District**, and **Northern Suburbs**.

The Badaling section is the most famous but also heavily restored and crowded. For a more enjoyable tourist experience, Mutianyu is recommended over Badaling; it offers similar restoration but with fewer crowds. Closer to the city center, about 60 km away in Changping District, is Juyongguan Pass, a well-known section of the Great Wall located in a deep gorge of the Taihang Mountains north of Beijing.

For those seeking less crowded areas, Jinshanling and Huanghuacheng are more challenging to reach by public transportation but offer stunning views of the wall away from the crowds. The distant Simatai section in the northeast can be combined with a night visit or an overnight stay at Gubei Watertown, a recreated historical village beside the wall.

Central Axis

The heart of Beijing is defined by the **Central Axis**, a historic north-south line that runs through the city's core, showcasing its rich heritage and urban planning. Originating during the Yuan Dynasty (1271–1368) when Beijing, then known as Dadu, became the capital, the Central Axis was further developed in the Ming (1368–1644) and refined in the Qing Dynasty (1636–1912). The urban layout reflects the ideal capital city as prescribed in the ancient text *Book of*

Diverse Crafts. In 2024, it was recognized as a  UNESCO World Heritage Site under the title "Beijing Central Axis: A Building Ensemble Exhibiting the Ideal Order of the Chinese Capital."

At the northern end of the Central Axis in the Gulou neighborhood stand the iconic **Drum and Bell Towers**, remnants of the medieval city that served as timekeeping centers during the Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties.

Proceeding south along the axis, you reach the **Forbidden City** (故宫博物院), the most significant landmark along the Central Axis. This vast imperial palace complex served as the residence of emperors during the Ming and Qing Dynasties and is a masterpiece of Chinese architecture. Remarkably, it remained largely untouched during the Cultural Revolution, thanks to Premier Zhou Enlai's intervention.



The Forbidden City



Temple of Heaven

Just south of the Forbidden City lies **Tiananmen Square**, located in the Dongcheng District. As the world's largest public square, it is a must-see destination surrounded by monumental buildings, including the Great Hall of the People, the National Museum of China, and the Chairman Mao Memorial Hall. The square also features the Monument to the People's Heroes and provides a grand entrance to the Forbidden City through the Tiananmen Gate.

Continuing further south is the arrow tower gate of **Zhengyangmen**, which marked the southern boundary of the Ming Dynasty's Inner City Wall. From the gate stretches Qianmen Street, a long, wide pedestrian street and perpendicular to it is Dashilar Commercial Street (see the Hutong section for more details). To the east of Zhengyangmen, slightly off the Central Axis, lies a 1.5-kilometer preserved section of the Inner City Wall, now repurposed as a park.

The axis then leads to the **Temple of Heaven** (天坛), an iconic symbol of Beijing. This magnificent temple complex, surrounded by a lively park, was where emperors of the Ming and Qing Dynasties performed annual ceremonies of prayer for a good harvest. The park is a popular gathering place for locals who enjoy activities like tai chi, calligraphy, and tea drinking.

At the southern end of the Central Axis stands the **Yongdingmen Gate**, a reconstruction completed in 2005. It looks like a Lego piece flanked by expressways. The gate serves as a poignant reminder of the Ming Dynasty's dismantled Outer City Wall rather than a tourism site.

Hutongs

Beijing's hutongs, its ancient alleyways, offer a glimpse into traditional architecture dating back to the Yuan Dynasty (1266-1368). These narrow lanes are lined with buildings typically constructed in the traditional courtyard style known as (四合院 *sìhéyuàn*). Originally, many of these courtyard homes were occupied by aristocrats, but after the Communist takeover in 1949,

they were displaced, and poorer families moved in. Today, hutongs can still be found throughout the area within the 2nd Ring Road, though many had been demolished to make way for new buildings and wider roads.

Some hutong areas, particularly around Qianmen and Houhai, are highly popular with tourists. One of the most visited sections is **Nanluoguxiang** (南锣鼓巷) in Dongcheng District, a historic lane from the Yuan Dynasty that stretches 786 meters long and 8 meters wide, which can become very crowded at peak times. Nanluoguxiang primarily offers snack shops and can become extremely crowded—during peak hours, you'll often find yourself weaving through throngs of people. Despite the crowds, the lively atmosphere and excellent people-watching make it a worthwhile visit. In the evenings, Nanluoguxiang is still bustling and serves as an alternative to the once-famous but now closed Wangfujing night market, though it lacks some Wangfujing specialty items like scorpion skewers.

Qianmen Street, located in Dongcheng District, is a bustling pedestrian street lined with stores representing traditional brands. Perpendicular to Qianmen Street is the **Dashilar Commercial Street** in the Xicheng District, another lively area with snacks and historic shops. While the streets showcase Beijing's rich commercial heritage, the addition of a modern shopping area, Beijing Fun, detracts from the area's traditional charm. For those seeking a more authentic experience, consider walking approximately 1.5 km west through the winding alleys of residential hutong neighborhoods (using a map app is recommended) to reach Liulichang, a relatively quiet hutong lane known for its art supplies.

If you're looking to escape the crowds of Nanluoguxiang and the Qianmen-Dashilar area, consider exploring another long hutong lane located south in Xicheng District, next to Fayuan Temple. Similar to Nanluoguxiang but far less crowded. This pedestrian area has a number of coffee shops, sharing a charm with other hidden coffee shop hutong areas, such as the alleys branching off Dongsì North Road, the small and cozy coffee shops of Wudaoying Hutong, and the area around Miaoying Temple (see more in the coffee section). These spots are perfect for a relaxing coffee break and a leisurely stroll.

Temples, Parks, and Nature

Beijing is home to numerous green oases that offer a refreshing escape from the city's bustling boulevards and narrow hutongs. These parks and natural spaces are beloved by locals for relaxation, sports, dancing, singing, and general recreation. Some of the best places to experience daily life in Beijing include the expansive **Chaoyang Park** (朝阳公园) and the more centrally located, compact **Ritan Park** (日坛公园), both in the Chaoyang District.

In the central districts of Beijing are the most notable temple and park sites in the city. In the Dongcheng District, you'll find the **Yonghegong** (Lama Temple) (雍和宫), one of China's most significant and beautiful temples, along with the nearby **Confucius Temple** (孔庙). Over in the Xicheng District, **Zhongshan Park** (中山公园) and **Beihai Park** (北海公园) are popular green spaces and part of the Central Axis, while the **Beijing Zoo** (北京动物园) is famous for its traditional landscaping and giant pandas.

The suburbs also offer attractions worth exploring. In the Haidian District, highlights include the majestic **Summer Palace** (颐和园), the ruins of the **Old Summer Palace** (圆明园), the scenic **Fragrant Hills** (香山), and the lush **Beijing Botanical Garden** (北京植物园). These sites are

close to one another, making them convenient to visit in a single trip.

Further afield, Beijing has two lesser-visited UNESCO World Heritage sites that may not be particularly captivating. The **Ming Tombs** in Changping District feature three open tombs, but excavations have ceased since 1989 due to previous botched attempts. In Fangshan District, the **Peking Man Site** at Zhoukoudian is notable for its archaeological discoveries, including early Homo erectus specimens; however, much of the original material was lost during the Japanese occupation in 1941, leaving only replicas on display. For a more interesting experience, consider visiting the Eastern Qing Tombs, which offer superior landscaping, although they are more challenging to access, as they are located in Zunhua in the neighboring province of Hebei.

For those spending an extended time in Beijing, consider popular day trips favored by locals. In rural Yanqing District, you can explore the often-overlooked **Guyaju Caves**, a fascinating complex of rock-carved dwellings believed to date back to the Tang Dynasty. Nearby, **Longqing Gorge**, known as the "Little Three Gorges" for its resemblance to the famous Three Gorges near Yichang, offers scenic views. In Fangshan District, you'll discover stunning natural caves formed by the region's karst landscape, some of which feature short boat trips through shallow waters inside the caves.

Museums and galleries

The museums in Beijing are generally not yet up to the standard seen in cities such as Paris, Rome, New York or even Taipei. However the city contains one of the largest and most well known museums in Asia, the **Palace Museum** also known as the Forbidden City. It is also a UNESCO World Heritage Site. China's government is determined to change the backward perception of its museums and has invested heavily in their development. It has also made most of them (not the Forbidden City) free to visit. However, for some museums, tickets must be reserved three days in advance.



Lights of the National Museum of China

One of the most well-known museums in Beijing is the **National Museum** (国家博物馆) in Dongcheng District, which was renovated in 2011. The **Military Museum** (军事博物馆) in Haidian District has long been a favorite with domestic and foreign tourists. The **Capital Museum** (首都博物馆) in Xicheng District is a new high-profile museum with historical and art exhibitions. The **China Aviation Museum** (中国民航博物馆) located in the Beijing/Northern Suburbs is surprisingly good and hosts 200+ rare and unique Chinese (mostly Russian) aircraft. Finally, a number of restored former residences of famous Beijingers, especially in Xicheng District, give a good insight into daily life in former times.

The **contemporary art scene** in Beijing is thriving, with numerous artists showcasing and selling their work in galleries throughout the city. The most established and easily accessible area is the **798 Art District** in Chaoyang District anchored by the UCCA Center for Contemporary Art. This district has a commercial atmosphere of mainstream galleries and luxury billboards dotting the area. Other notable art districts include the **Caochangdi Art District** in Chaoyang District and the **Songzhuang Art Community** in Tongzhou District. Yanjiao, outside of Beijing, is home to studios of young artists who had sought lower rents in Hebei province.

Skyline and contemporary architecture

In contrast to the historical landmarks, Chaoyang District offers contemporary symbols of modern Beijing. The **National Stadium** (commonly known as the Bird's Nest) stands as an enduring symbol of the 2008 Olympic Games. Nearby, the striking **CCTV Headquarters** has become an icon of contemporary Beijing, surrounded by the city's skyline, which includes supertall structures like the China World Trade Center Tower 3, Tower 3B, and the China Zun.

Do

Individual listings can be found in Beijing's district articles

■ Hiking, camping, and tobogganing on the Great Wall:

- There are numerous hiking options available on the Great Wall, with various tours and groups offering guided experiences, such as the well-established but expensive tour operator Beijing Hikers (<https://www.beijinghikers.com/get-information/how-to-choose-the-best-great-wall-hike/>). The unrestored Jiankou section, although dangerous, is often considered the most beautiful. Many of the "wild" sections of the Wall are ideal for both hiking and camping.
- A recommended overnight camping spot can be arranged by visiting the village of Chenjiapu in Yanqing District, where the Chen family at Great Wall Fresh (<http://www.greatwallfresh.com/>) offers homestays and tent rentals. Alternatively, just further west of Chenjiapu village in Huailai County, in the neighboring province of Hebei, you can find an empty 1 km stretch of restored Wall and bring your own tent.
- At the Mutianyu section in Huairou District, there is even a toboggan rail slide that allows visitors to ride down the Great Wall in a wheelless sled.
- **Bike through the hutongs:** Exploring the remaining hutongs by bicycle is a fantastic way to experience Beijing firsthand. See above for bike rental information. Cesar (<https://www.beijinghutongtrips.com/>) from Barcelona, a top hutong aficionado, organizes biking tours of the hutongs in English and Spanish.
- **Get a foot massage** Have a highly enjoyable and relaxing foot massage and/or pedicure etc (for a fraction of the price in the West) from any of the respectable and professional offerings in central Beijing (in the vicinity of the Beijing Hotel for example).



Great Wall of China at Badaling



Theaters and concert halls

The **National Centre for the Performing Arts** in Xicheng District offers a variety of performances including opera, music, and theatre. Even if you don't attend a performance, the egg shaped building itself is worth a visit. The exterior is made from a steel oval structure that includes over 18,000 titanium plates and 1,000 sheets of ultra-white glass.

Beijing Opera (京剧 *jīngjù*) is most popular style of traditional Chinese opera nationwide. This kind of opera is nothing like Western opera, with the costumes, singing style, music and spectator reactions being distinctly Chinese. The plot is usually quite simple and drawn from popular stories set in ancient China, so you might be able to understand some of what happens even if you do not understand the language; some theatres also provide English surtitles for the benefit of tourists. The most distinctive feature of Beijing opera you will notice that distinguishes it from other traditional Chinese opera styles is the elaborate face paint worn by the main characters. Some of the best places to watch Beijing Opera are found in Xicheng District including Huguang Guild Hall (<https://www.huguangguildhall.com/>) (湖广会馆 *Húguāng Huìguān*), Liyuan Theatre (<https://liyuantheatre.cn/>) (梨园剧场 *Líyuán Jùchǎng*) and the Mei Lanfang Grand Theatre (<http://www.bjmlfdjy.cn/>) (梅兰芳大剧场 *Méi Lánfāng Dà Jùyuàn*). There are also a number in Dongcheng District including Chang'an Grand Theatre (<https://www.changandaxiyuan.cn/>) (长安大戏院 *Cháng'ān Dà Xìyuàn*).

Acrobatics shows are also worth a visit if you want to see some traditional Chinese entertainment. Some of the best shows are found in Tianqiao Acrobatics Theatre in Xicheng District and in Chaoyang Theatre in Chaoyang District.

Beijing is famous among the Chinese for its **drama plays** (话剧 *huàjù*), and some of the more famous theatres for contemporary Chinese plays include the Capital Theatre in Dongcheng District and Century Theater in Chaoyang District. However, performances of Western plays are rare.

Classical music is also popular in Beijing. Some of the best places to go are the National Centre for the Performing Arts and the Century Theater both mentioned above as well as Beijing Concert Hall in Xicheng District.

Learn

Chinese (Mandarin) Lessons

Beijing offers many schools that provide Mandarin lessons for foreigners:

- **LTL Mandarin School** (<https://ltl-beijing.com/>): Specializes in teaching Chinese through various programs, including small group classes, individual classes, and immersion. Students have the opportunity to live with Chinese homestay families, participate in full immersion trips to smaller cities around China, and study in small groups or one-on-one in the Central Business District.
- **Hutong School Beijing** (<https://www.hutong-school.com/learn-chinese-beijing>): Located in Sanlitun, this school offers a wide range of Chinese courses, including intensive programs, HSK preparation, business Chinese, and classes for children. Both group and private classes are available, taught by experienced native teachers.
- **That's Mandarin** (<https://www.thatsmandarin.com/learn-chinese-in-china>): Established in 2005, this school offers both short-term Chinese courses (starting from 2 weeks) and long-term courses, which are eligible for student visas.

Cooking Classes

Beijing is an excellent destination for gourmet tours and exploring the culture and traditions through food. Not only can you enjoy the rich flavors of Chinese cuisine, but you also have the opportunity to acquire new culinary skills, bringing home a piece of Chinese culture.

- **Black Sesame Kitchen** (<http://www.blacksesamekitchen.com>), 3 Black Sesame Hutong, Dongcheng District, blacksesamekitchenteam@gmail.com (<mailto:blacksesamekitchenteam@gmail.com>). Try your hand at creating a variety of Chinese dishes, from cold starters to famous noodles and dumplings. Classes are conducted in English, and you can also enjoy a fancy dinner with explanations of major flavors and the significance of different ingredients. Reservations are required.
- **Beijing Cookery** (<http://www.beijingcookingschool.com/>), info@beijingcookingschool.com (<mailto:info@beijingcookingschool.com>). Join a cooking class focused on Hutong cuisine, offering hands-on experiences in preparing traditional dishes. An optional market tour is available for an additional fee.
- **The Hutong** (<http://www.thehutong.com/>), 1 Jiu Dao Wan Zhong Xiang Hutong, Dongcheng District (东城区九道湾中巷1号), info@thehutong.com (<mailto:info@thehutong.com>). Located in a traditional courtyard home in downtown Beijing, The Hutong offers a variety of Chinese cultural programs. Visitors can attend market tours, cooking classes (both Chinese and international), tea tastings, and traditional Chinese medicine sessions. You can also enjoy private meals, events, or simply relax on the rooftop terrace with a view of authentic hutong culture. Chefs, guides, and teachers speak English, Chinese, Spanish, Dutch, and more by request.

Universities

Beijing is the main centre of higher learning in China. Peking and Tsinghua Universities are the most prestigious universities in China, and also ranked among the best in the world. Admission to these two universities is extremely competitive for Chinese students, though it is considerably easier for international students provided your Mandarin is up to scratch. Most of the universities are clustered in Haidian District in the northwestern part of the city and nearly all of the universities in Beijing accept foreign students.



Tsinghua University, Beijing, China. Founded in 1911 

- **Peking University** (<http://english.pku.edu.cn/>) (北京大学 Běijīng Dàxué). China's most prestigious general university. Colloquially known by its shortened name 北大 (Běidà). It hosts the Yenching Academy (<https://yenchingacademy.pku.edu.cn/>), which offers a highly competitive scholarship for international students to pursue a master's program in China Studies.
- **Tsinghua University** (<https://www.tsinghua.edu.cn/>) (清华大学 Qīnghuá Dàxué). China's most prestigious university for technical subjects. It offers the Schwarzman Scholars (<https://www.schwarzmanscholars.org/>) program, a highly competitive scholarship for international students to study a one-year master's in Global Affairs, similar to Yenching but with greater global name recognition.

- **Peking Union College of Medicine** (<https://www.pumch.cn/en/introduction.html>). China's most prestigious medical school.
- **Renmin University of China** (<https://www.tsinghua.edu.cn/>). China's top university for humanities and social sciences including the nation's most prestigious law school.
- **China Agricultural University** (<http://en.cau.edu.cn/>). Renowned for agricultural research. CAU offers Chinese government scholarships to citizens of African countries for the "Science and Technology Backyard", "Rural Vitalization," and "Simple Technology, Big Harvest" master's programs, focusing on agronomy and technology.

Work

See also: [Working in China](#)

Beijing is a major hub for business and technology companies. The Central Business District (CBD) around Guomao and Wangjing, both in the [Chaoyang District](#) are popular office areas for international business. Haidian District is home to many of China's largest tech companies, and Financial Street in [Xicheng District](#) houses major banks and insurance companies. The Lize Financial Business District in Fengtai District, anchored by the Leeza SOHO tower with its curvy design, was launched just before the pandemic and is set to have a direct subway connection to Daxing Airport by 2025.



Guomao



For entrepreneurs looking to establish a foothold in Beijing, the [German Centre](https://www.germancentre.com/en/beijing/) (<https://www.germancentre.com/en/beijing/>) offers office space within a unique ecosystem that houses over 70 German companies and key organizations. The German Centre is supported by German government institutions and offers market knowledge and advice to entrepreneurs.

In Beijing, as in much of China, finding a job [teaching English](#) at a training center is relatively easy for native speakers, making it a popular option for South Africans. However, if you're aiming to work at an international school, employers typically require teaching credentials from your home country or several years of teaching experience. Additionally, policies aimed at reducing the cost of raising children generally discourage hiring foreign teachers in schools. Non-native speakers, even from other Western countries, should be cautious about teaching English jobs, as strict enforcement of regulations includes the risk of administrative detention for violations.

Buy

Individual listings can be found in [Beijing's district articles](#)

Beijing is home to many high-net-worth households and offers a wide range of upscale shopping destinations catering to locals. Tourists can enjoy shopping at popular spots like Wangfujing, the Qianmen area, and Hongqiao Pearl Market.

Wangfujing in Dongcheng District is a long, bustling shopping street with additional stores around the large shopping area. This expansive pedestrian street spans several blocks and is lined with numerous shopping complexes, including the iconic Wangfujing Department Store, easily recognizable by its clocktower overlooking the avenue. Big-name brands are well represented here, and one intersection even features flagship Huawei and Apple stores directly facing each other. The Wangfujing Bookstore offers a small selection of English-language books, mostly classics like *Hamlet* and *1984*. It's also a great spot for kids due to its large children's section. As of Jan 2025, the Beijing Foreign Languages Bookstore is closed for renovation and is expected to reopen in late 2025. Wangfujing is one of two classic shopping areas in Beijing that have evolved into high-end districts, the other being Xidan Commercial Street in Xicheng District (west of the central axis, while Wangfujing is to the east).



Dashilar Commercial Street



For a more traditional and touristy shopping experience, visit the bustling streets of **Qianmen Street** in Dongcheng District, located near one of the city's Ming Dynasty wall gates. Nearby is the perpendicular **Dashilar Commercial Street** in Xicheng District. Both streets have a historical Chinese architectural backdrop. In Qianmen, you can find traditional Chinese food shops such as Daoxiangcun, famous for its pastries, and Liubiju Pickle Shop, which offers a variety of pickled delicacies—though both might be an acquired taste. The Qianmen-Dashilar area also features markets selling cultural goods, including silk clothing, porcelain, teas, and other traditional items. For those seeking a quieter and more authentic experience than the tourist-heavy Qianmen-Dashilar area, a short walk west leads to Liulichang, a relatively peaceful hutong lane renowned for its art supplies, including calligraphy materials, paintings, and books.

Panjiayuan Market in Chaoyang District is famous for cultural gifts and imitation antiques, making it a great spot for unique souvenirs.

If you're interested in exploring local markets, two other options are worth considering. **Chongwenmen Market** (崇文门市场), a market for vegetables and groceries, has a reputation throughout the city for quality. For tea enthusiasts, **Maliandao Tea Street** (马连道) is a vast wholesale market for tea but not a tourist destination.

For upscale malls, two standout options are perfect for shoppers seeking a high-end experience. **Taikoo Li** in the Sanlitun neighborhood showcases Beijing's trendy consumer scene. Along with Sanlitun Soho across the street, it forms a hub ideal for people-watching. Entering Taikoo Li feels like stepping onto a runway—the narrow walkway from the main intersection opens into a spacious outdoor mall buzzing with activity, including photographers snapping pictures of stylish girls. Nearby is **Parkview Green**, a distinctive high-end mall featuring contemporary art installations and a cozy café on the 10th floor. Both destinations are located in the Chaoyang District.

Eat

Individual listings can be found in [Beijing's district articles](#)

Beijing provides an ideal opportunity to sample food from all over the country. Some of Beijing's best restaurants serve food from [Sichuan](#), [Hunan](#), [Guangzhou](#), [Tibet](#), [Yunnan](#), [Xinjiang](#), and more.

Restaurant areas

One of Beijing's most famous streets for food is undoubtedly **Guijie** (簋街 / 鬼街). This vibrant street, located in the [Dongcheng District](#), is a true haven for food lovers, offering a wide array of excellent cuisines. Stretching over a kilometer, Guijie is home to more than 150 eateries, with around 90% of its commercial spaces dedicated to dining.



Guijie at night

As a global city, Beijing offers a rich variety of international restaurants, particularly in the [Chaoyang District](#). The dining scene is centered around Sanlitun and stretches west to the Worker's Stadium, north to the diplomatic area, and south to the Central Business District. In this vibrant area, you can find a wide range of international options, including gourmet burger joints, sandwich shops, and taquerias. Beijing's strong diplomatic ties to the Global South also bring unique offerings, such as chicken jollof rice from Ghana and [BBQ from Pakistan](#) (<http://khanbababeijing.com/>). Within the Sanlitun subdistrict, **Xingfucun Zhonglu**, a small side street, and a short section of Xindong Lu, a larger main street perpendicular to Xingfucun, is home to the city's most westernized section of dining. Here, you'll find steakhouses, craft beer, bakeries, and coffee shops located close together. April Gourmet, a small grocery store selling imported Western foods, is also nearby. For a quick, cheap bite, Greek Freak, at the corner of Xingfucun and Xindong Lu, serves Greek gyros (36 yuan) and Hungarian goulash (42 yuan).

For a distinct international dining experience, visit **Shenlu Jie**, located north of Ritan Park, also in the [Chaoyang District](#). This neighborhood, marked by Cyrillic signs, is lined with restaurants serving Central and West Asian cuisines and even features a Russian grocery store. One standout spot is Kavkaz, run by an Azerbaijani entrepreneur, which offers dishes from across the former Soviet Union and boasts the best sheesha in Beijing.

Muslim visitors should head to the area around Niujie Mosque in [Xicheng District](#), where you will find a vibrant Hui Muslim community with many of **halal** butchers and restaurants.

Peking duck

Peking duck (北京烤鸭 *Běijīng kǎoyā*) is a famous Beijing speciality served at many restaurants, but there are quite a few restaurants dedicated to the art of roasting the perfect duck. Peking duck is served with thin pancakes, plum sauce (甜面酱 *tiánmiàn jiàng*), and slivers of scallions and cucumbers. You dip the duck in the sauce and roll it up in the pancake with a few slivers of

scallions and/or cucumbers. The end result is a mouthwatering combination of the cool crunchiness of the cucumber, the sharpness of the scallions, and the rich flavours of the duck. The two best known restaurants are Dadong or Quanjude.

Other specialties

Beijing is also known for its mutton hotpot (涮羊肉 *shuàn yáng ròu*), which originally came from the Manchu people and emphasizes mutton over other meats. Like variations of hotpot (general name 火锅 *huǒ guō*) from elsewhere in China and Japan, hotpot is a cook-it-yourself affair in a steaming pot in the center of the table. Unlike Sichuan hotpot, mutton hotpot features a savory, non-spicy broth. If that's not exciting enough for you, you can also request a spicy broth (one that is flaming red, filled with peppers, and not for the weak!) To play it safe and satisfy everyone, you can request a yuan-yang (鸳鸯 *yuānyáng*) pot divided down the middle, with spicy broth on one side and regular broth on the other. Raw ingredients are purchased by the plate, including other types of meat and seafood, vegetables, mushrooms, noodles, and tofu, so it's also perfectly possible to have vegetarian hotpot. A dipping sauce, usually sesame, is served as well; you can add chilis, garlic, cilantro, etc., to customize your own sauce. While "raw" sounds dangerous, boiling the meat yourself is the best way to ensure that more risky meats like pork are fully cooked and free of germs.

For those who have a sweet tooth or enjoys snacks, Beijing is a city with a lot more choices. Traditional snacks like "Lvdagun" (驴打滚 means "Donkey rolling in the muddle", made from rice and red beans) "Wandouhuang" (豌豆黄 means the yellow peas, made from yellow peas, soft) "Fulingbing" (茯苓饼 means poria cocos pancake or a fuling pancake, usually made from a mixture of the herbal plant and flour and stuffings) and so many other kinds.

Street food

Some of the cheapest and most delicious meals can be had on the streets. For a tourist street food experience, start at Wangfujing has a "snack street" selling such mundane fare like lamb, chicken, and beef as well as multiple styles of noodle dishes, such as Sichuan style rice noodles, but the brave can also sample silkworm, scorpion, and various organs all skewered on a stick and grilled to order.



Peking Duck



mutton hotpot



Lvdagun

Savory pancakes (煎饼果子 *Jiānbǐng guǒzi*) are one of the most popular street snacks, eaten from morning till night with most carts operating during the morning commute and then opening again at night for the after-club crowds and night-owls. This delicious pancake is cooked with an egg on a griddle, a fried dough crisp is added, and the whole thing is drizzled in scallions and a savory sauce. Hot sauce is optional. Diehard fans often go on a quest for the best cart in the city. Lamb kebabs (羊肉串儿 *yáng ròu chuàn r*) and other kebabs are grilled on makeshift stands all around Beijing, from the late afternoon to late at night. A winter speciality, candied haw berries (冰糖葫芦 *bīng táng hú lu*) are dipped in molten sugar which is left to harden in the cold and sold on a stick. You can also find variations with oranges, grapes, strawberries, and bananas, or dipped in crumbled peanuts as well as sugar. This sweet snack can also sometimes be found in the spring and the summer, but the haw berries are often from last season's crop.



Savory pancakes (煎饼果子 *Jiānbǐng guǒzi*)

Vegetarians

Beijing is not known for vegetarian fare, though there are vegetarian restaurants scattered across the city catering to devout Buddhists. The most renowned vegetarian restaurant is King's Joy (京兆尹), a fine dining experience of vegetarian dishes made with green, seasonal produce sourced from local organic farms. The restaurant is located at Wudaoying Hutong in the Dongcheng District.

Drink

Individual listings can be found in Beijing's district articles

Tea

Tea, tea, and more tea! Beijing offers a variety of tea experiences, from simple shops in malls to stand-alone establishments. Whether you're in a bustling commercial center or a quieter neighborhood, always ask the price before ordering, or you might end up paying a premium for what could be the most expensive egg-sized cup of tea in the world. In particular, the Qianmen area south of Tiananmen Square is known for its tea houses, where you can experience different styles of tea ceremonies and tastings. However, be mindful that the quality and price can vary significantly. Some tea houses are genuine cultural experiences, while others are little more than tourist traps designed to milk you of your money (see the warning below about tea tasting scams).

There are teahouses around the historic Qianhai Hutong, offering a serene ambiance reminiscent of old wooden houses, with tea cups and bowls adorning the interior. You can enjoy a wide variety of teas, though be prepared for some steep prices—some teas can cost CNY200 or more. Ideal for couples and families.

Coffee

Excellent coffee can be found in independent cafés scattered throughout the city.

Within the Second Ring Road in central Beijing, you'll find numerous hutong cafés tucked away in the alleyways. A notable area in the Dongcheng District is Dongsì North Road, a wide street lined with cafés. If you venture into the alleys branching off from the main road, you'll discover hidden gems for coffee. As you walk north toward the Second Ring Road, you'll come across Wudaoying Hutong, a long and narrow pedestrian street filled with small cafés dedicated to high-quality coffee, alongside trendy shops and restaurants. It's also the most relaxed pedestrian street in Beijing.

For a more scenic coffee experience, visit the hutongs surrounding Miaoying Temple in the Xicheng District. These cafés often have rooftop terraces offering stunning views of the 13th-century pagoda designed by a Nepalese architect. Strolling or circumambulating around the temple and through the winding hutong neighborhood paths, you'll stumble upon charming spots for a coffee or a beer.

Baijiu and beer

Baijiu (白酒 *báijiǔ*) is the quintessential Chinese spirit, typically distilled from grains such as sorghum. While there are many affordable options available, Maotai (茅台 *Máotái*) is considered the national liquor and is highly regarded. Prices for Maotai start at around ¥1,500. For a premium selection, visit the Maotai store at the Westin Beijing Financial Street, facing Wudinghou Street on the first floor. The store offers an extensive variety of Maotai, including the rare 6-liter Methuselah bottle of Maotai, priced at ¥48,800. Another top-tier baijiu is Wuliangye (五粮液), priced around ¥1,000, known for its smoother taste that might be more approachable for newcomers. For a taste of the typical swill, there is Erguotou (二锅头 *Èrguōtóu*), a strong and inexpensive baijiu, can be found at any convenience store in 500ml bottles with the red star brand.



Maotai



When it comes to beer, popular choices include Tsingtao (青岛 *Qīngdǎo*) and Yanjing (燕京 *Yànjīng*), with the latter being Beijing's own local mass produced brew. For craft beer enthusiasts, Great Leap Brewing (大跃) and Slowboat are notable local microbreweries. Great Leap has a unique location nestled in the hutongs near Gulou.

Places to drink

Most of Beijing's bars are found in one of the bar clusters around the city. In the beginning there was only one was Sanlitun, but many areas have emerged.

- **Sanlitun** in Chaoyang District been the centre of nightlife in Beijing for a long time. It is also the hub of Beijing's LGBT community, and home to the largest concentration of gay bars in the city.
- **Nanluoguxiang and surrounding hutongs** in Dongcheng District located in the middle of the hutongs in the Gulou neighborhood, east of the Drum and Bell Towers; finding hard to

locate bars in a maze of hutong alleys is one of the unique pleasures of nightlife in Beijing.

- **Workers Stadium** in Chaoyang District and adjacent to Sanlitun; clubs line the east side of the stadium complex.
- **Wudaokou** in Haidian District is the hangout spot for foreign and local university students; the bar street is anchored by a 7-11 where drinkers mill about outside.
- **Houhai** in Xicheng District is a bar area located on Houhai Lake, west of the Bell and Drum Towers; once thriving but popularity has faded since the 2000s.

Sleep

Individual listings can be found in Beijing's district articles

Beijing offers a wide range of accommodations starting with budget options under 300 yuan. Rates for a four-star hotel typically start at around 500 yuan, while five-star hotels range from 1,200 to 2,100 yuan. Several luxury hotels exceed the typical rates of standard five-star options, including the Rosewood Beijing, Peninsula Beijing, Mandarin Oriental Wangfujing, and the ultra-luxurious Bvlgari Hotel. Most of the expensive hotels are found in the Dongcheng District and along the eastern 3rd Ring Road in Chaoyang District.

For unique overnight experiences, particularly near the Great Wall, consider staying in the outlying areas. One option is to pitch a tent on the Great Wall and sleep under the shelter of a guard tower. The easiest way to arrange this is by visiting the village of Chenjiapu in Yanqing District, where the Chen family at Great Wall Fresh (<http://www.greatwallfresh.com/>) can rent you a tent for 100 yuan.

Since the pandemic, international tourism in China is still recovering, resulting in a limited number of hostels with foreign travelers and backpackers at any given time. A notable option for backpackers is the Pagoda Light (北京白塔之光酒店), located next to the beautiful 13th-century Baitasi stupa in the Xicheng District. This hostel features a rooftop café and restaurant with a grand view of the stupa. While Airbnb does not operate in China, you can explore alternative options by searching for hosts on Couchsurfing (https://www.couchsurfing.com/place?location_text=Beijing%2C+Beijing%2C+China).

For longer-term accommodation, be prepared to splurge as Beijing's real estate prices are among the highest in the world, even surpassing those in Western European cities. Expect to spend around 7,000-8,000 yuan per month for a short-term lease on a studio apartment in the city center.

Stay safe

Emergencies

Free emergency telephone numbers:

- Police: **110**.
- Fire alarm: **119**.
- Medical care: **120**.

Remember these three telephone numbers; they are valid in almost every part of China.

Scams and crime

Beijing, despite its size, is a very safe city, with violent crime being incredibly rare. It is generally safe for women to walk alone at night, and there is a significant police presence in the city center.

Tourists visiting Beijing should be vigilant about scams and petty crime, especially in tourist-heavy areas like Tiananmen Square and routes to the Great Wall. Pickpocketing can happen in crowded places, so it is important to keep your belongings secure and within sight at all times. Taxi-related scams are particularly prevalent, so refer to the "Avoiding scams and fakes" section under the taxi heading for detailed advice on how to navigate this issue safely.

While many Beijing locals are genuinely curious about foreigners and may simply wish to chat or take a photo, it's important to remain cautious and stick to your original plans. If you are approached with an invitation to go somewhere unexpected, it's wise to politely decline and continue with your plans. Be wary of locals—often posing as students or artists—who invite tourists to exhibitions or tea tastings, which can lead to pressure to make expensive purchases.

Traffic

Pedestrians should be very careful crossing the street: People will generally stop for you, but they will honk. Keep an eye on the locals and cross with them — there is strength in numbers. Cars don't need to stop at a red light when they are turning right. Although the traffic law gives the first priority to pedestrians, not every driver obeys the rule.

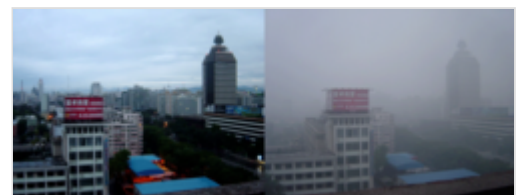
Stay healthy

See the ***Chinese Stay Healthy*** article for general health and food advice.

See ***Chinese Smog*** article for air pollution issues.

Tap water in Beijing is not safe for drinking. Hygiene for cooked food is generally not an issue. Chinese people place a lot of emphasis on the freshness of their food, so any food you eat is usually cooked to order. However, be wary if you plan to eat cold or raw dishes.

Air pollution and smog has traditionally been a big problem in Beijing like any other big city in China. Coal burning and industrial emissions in the surrounding region makes for very unhealthy air. Since 2018 air quality has significantly improved. It's a good idea to check the air-quality readings online first thing every morning. Hazardous air may continue for several days before precipitation or a gust of wind clears the air. Readings of air quality updated by the hour for Beijing and other Chinese cities can be found at aqicn.org ([htt](http://aqicn.org)



Heavy air pollution has resulted in widespread smog. These photographs, taken in August 2005, show the variations in Beijing's air quality. 

Face Masks for Pollution

A white surgical face mask may help with the occasional dust storms, but a simple fabric or paper mask will not protect you against smaller airborne particles. Most smog or haze outbreaks are made up of fine particles that are 2.5 microns or

[p://www.aqicn.org](http://www.aqicn.org)). If it is "unhealthy" or "hazardous", consider cutting back on your activities if they are likely to involve a lot of walking outside, in favor of visits to museums or shops.

smaller (PM2.5). N95 or KN95 masks provide good protection against smog as they are at least 95% efficient against fine particles that are about 0.1 – 0.3 microns.

Chinese public hospitals are generally not recommended for travelers due to the lack of English-speaking staff. For those seeking medical assistance in Beijing, the following hospitals are recommended as they offer services in English. Raffles Medical Beijing and Beijing United Family Hospital are expensive private facilities with English-speaking doctors. Public hospitals with good language resources include Peking Union Medical College Hospital and Beijing Sino-Japanese Friendship Hospital. The four hospitals are listed on the [Australian Embassy website](https://china.embassy.gov.au/bjng/HOSPITALLIST.html) for travelers (<https://china.embassy.gov.au/bjng/HOSPITALLIST.html>).

For dental care in central Beijing, you can visit the Peking University Hospital of Stomatology 5th Outpatient Department (北大口腔第五门诊部). The clinic follows an efficient process. Unlike some places where dentists may try to upsell by identifying unnecessary issues, you won't encounter that here. They charge 468 yuan for a cleaning. It's recommended to book an appointment through their app for convenience with a small additional fee of 20 yuan.

Cope

Mobile payments

See also: [China § Mobile payments](#)

Visa and Mastercard are rarely accepted so it is essential to set up WeChat Pay (<https://pay.weixin.qq.com/index.php/public/wechatpay>) (微信支付 *Wēixìn zhīfù*) and Alipay (<https://global.alipay.com/>) (支付宝 *Zhīfùbaǒ*). See main article for details for on installing the apps.

Internet access

See also: [China § VPN](#)

The Great Firewall of China blocks popular web services including Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, YouTube, Google, WhatsApp, Telegram and many others including Wikipedia. To bypass internet restrictions and access popular websites, travelers often use VPN services. See section in the [China](#) article for recommendations. Be sure to install the VPN before arriving in China; attempting to do so after landing can be problematic as the service might already be blocked.

Worship

For Muslim worshippers, a visit to the Niujie Mosque in the [Xicheng District](#) is highly recommended. As the oldest mosque in Beijing, it is not only a place for prayer but also a cornerstone of the city's Islamic heritage. The surrounding Niujie Street (Ox Street) is the lively heart of Beijing's Muslim community, offering halal dining options and an immersive cultural experience.

The Archbishop of Beijing, like all bishops in China, is in communion with the Pope. The Diocese of Beijing is home to several historic churches where Sunday Masses are offered in Chinese, Latin, French, and Italian. You can check the schedule on this [website \(https://weekdaymasses.org.uk/en/day/U/area/beijing\)](https://weekdaymasses.org.uk/en/day/U/area/beijing).

For parishioners of the Russian Orthodox Church, the Dormition of the Most Holy Theotokos Church is the primary place of worship in Beijing. Located within the Russian Embassy in Dongcheng District, it is the only Orthodox parish in the Chinese capital. Regular services are held on Saturdays, Sundays, and feast days. The church also offers a Sunday Catechetical School for English-speaking parishioners, which takes place every Sunday at 12:00 in the church library. Visitors have to plan their visit accordingly (<https://orthodoxbj.com/en/requirements/>).

In Fangshan District, lies the site of the city's earliest known church, Shizisi (Temple of the Cross). Dating back possibly to the 7th century, this Nestorian Christian church has a fascinating history reflecting the presence of the Assyrian Church of the East in China. Little of the original structure remains, but the site is marked by two ancient stone inscriptions.

Embassies

Beijing is one of the world's largest diplomatic hubs and a good place to obtain visas.

Diplomatic missions	list [Expand]
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Go next

- [Tianjin](#) — One of China's largest cities, known for its history as a foreign trade port and its European-style architecture. It is accessible from Beijing by high-speed rail in as little as 31 minutes.
- [Chengde](#) — Home to the Summer Mountain Resort, located approximately 256 km (159 mi) northeast of Beijing. You can reach Chengde by high-speed rail in about one hour.
- [Shanghai](#) — The largest city in China, reachable from Beijing by a 2-hour flight or by high-speed train in approximately 4.5 hours.
- [Mongolia](#) — Overland travel to Mongolia is possible via the Inner Mongolia port of [Erlian](#) (二连), which can be accessed from Beijing by a low cost 1 hour, 35 minute flight.

Routes through Beijing (rail)

			END ←	N		Jingguang Railway	S →	Shijiazhuang → Zhengzhou
			END ←	W		Jingha Railway	E →	Tianjin → Harbin
			END ←	W		Jinghu Railway	E →	Tianjin → Shanghai
			END ←	N		Jingjiu Railway	S →	Heze → Shenzhen →  → Kowloon
Moscow ← Irkutsk ←  ← Ulaanbaatar ←  ← Hohhot				N		Trans-Siberian Railway	S →	END

Routes through Beijing (road)

END ←	W		G1	E →	Tianjin → Harbin
END ←	N		G2	S →	Tianjin → Shanghai
END ←	N		G3	S →	Tianjin → Jinan
END ←	N		G4	S →	Shijiazhuang → Shenzhen

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